

The triple constraint of hangin' out



Pictured: The holy trinity of essential things to figure out when planning an outing.

This diagram represents the absolutely necessary decisions for any event planning. Sure, there can be more dimensions (e.g. do you take +1s? Should I bring anything?) but virtually all events require at least these three parameters. The issue is that defining all three of them is too much mental work, especially right at the time when there's an initiative to hang out. For example, assume you stumble upon a friend at the local farmer's market. The interaction would probably go like this:

- "Hey <Insert Name>, it's been a while!"
- "I agree! It's been some time! How have you been?"
- ...
- [insert 5 minutes of small talk]
- ...
- "Anyway, I gotta go. We should hang out sometime!"
- "I agree, we should!"
- "... yeah"
- "Okay!"
- "See you!" *walks away*

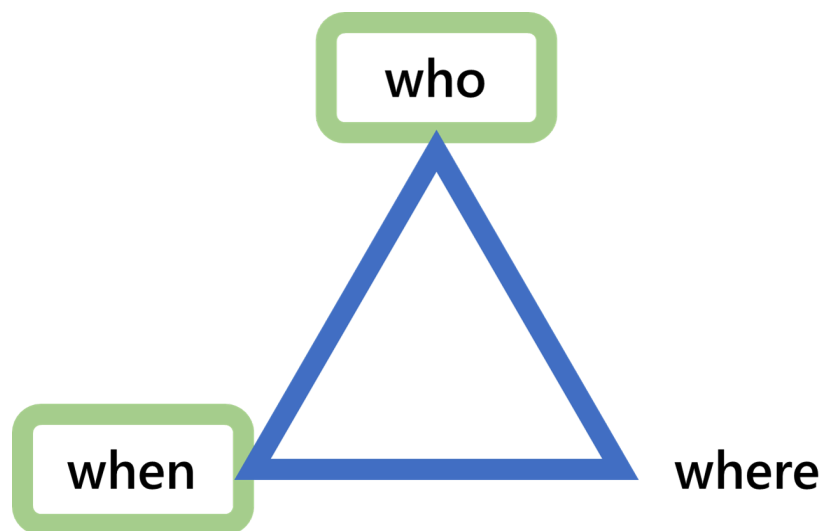
Narrator: And they didn't hang out.

Let's assume that this interaction is genuine. The moment when the friend surfaces the idea of hanging out, there's a little shock that happens. The necessary step would be to materialize the event details as much as possible which would involve switching context: putting your grocery bags down, bringing your phones out, looking at calendars, thinking of things to do, etc. The

who? is clear, but the next comes the **when?**, which requires information about availability, presence and so on. And the **where?** has a little more flexibility, so it could probably come later.

In an ideal world, all the variables could be sorted out immediately. We have the necessary data in our work/personal calendars to figure out our availability and provide options, and we have lots of places data to curate and recommend meeting points. If it was that easy, however, there would already be a widely-adopted solution to this problem. The missing piece here is that... we are human. We like to make some decisions later once we have more information, or once we have a chance to think about it. If asking too many questions at once was easy for event planning, then Facebook events would be the defacto standard for every single one of my hangouts.

The framework I'm proposing to tackle planning with the human requirement of postponing decisions uses the 3-constrained triangle with permutations of two options at a time. Let's explore them:



who? + when?

This is the most optimal of the 3 permutations. By figuring out availability that works for both parties, the decision of **where?** could be postponed even until the very last minute. Examples of this interaction are:

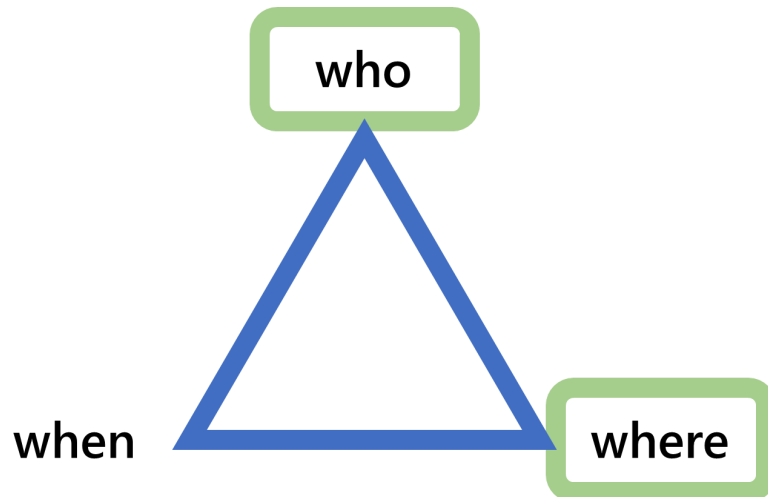
“Let’s hang out next weekend! I’m free on Saturday afternoon, let’s see what the weather’s like”

“Let’s get lunch on Monday, we’ll see what we’re feeling”

“Let’s get drinks on Friday! I’ll text you where we’ll end up”

This permutation also provides a very rich space for place recommendations. The platform can derive context from these parameters and suggest places. This context can be expanded by a

data-rich application using GPS location, any saved personal preferences, history of previous events and so on.



who? + where?

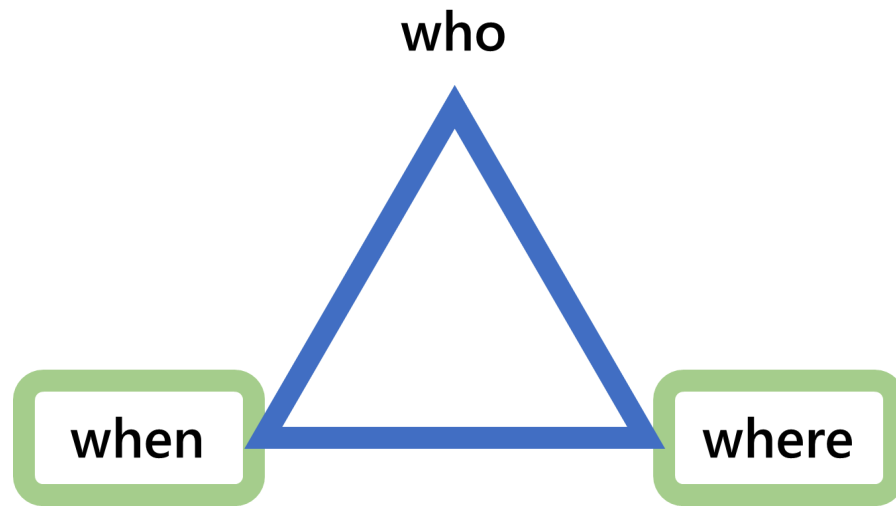
A less optimal permutation but common nonetheless. This is a place-centered initiative where the location is fixed and potentially reflective of a mutual interest of the two parties. Examples of texts of this kind are:

“They just opened a new tacos place in Rainier! Let’s go check it out sometime?”

“We should catch a show at Neumos again, I love this venue!”

“I haven’t been to the Space needle yet, would you like to come with me?”

The value provided by the platform in this case is highlighted by the ability to provide options and alternatives, as well as allowing for flexibility in case of rescheduling. Some events have a where+when entanglement where this is easier to solve (festivals, parades, concerts, any planned event).



when? + where?

Anyone with hobbies and interests has experienced the desire to go somewhere and leave an open invitation for others to join. These are often sent to a group chat where people have location and context in common. Examples of texts of this kind are:

“I’m going to run in Greenlake tomorrow at 8am, in case anyone would like to join”

“I’m going to the Cage the Elephant concert this weekend. Does anyone know of them?”

“I’m getting lunch at 11:30 today on campus, meet at Cafe 16?”

In this case, the value provided by the platform would be the ability to surface the opportunity to others proactively, without requiring the user to craft any text messages or manually choose who to invite.

who? || when? || where?

When organizers start with a single variable, every other decision is postponable and open to options. This is the most complex case to solve, but it is still possible nonetheless. This is also the event type that provides the most opportunity for value for the platform. For each combination, these are the possible solutions:

1. **who?** Examples: “Let’s get again together! We’ll follow up”.
2. **where?** Examples: “Let’s come again to this restaurant sometime”
3. **when?** Examples